English Phrasebook for German-Speaking Presenters — ABCC 2027

ABCC 2027 preparation · 04 · Training

For the HSBI team and coach. The Asper Business Case Competition (February 18–22, 2027, Winnipeg) is conducted **entirely in English**: a 25-minute prepared-case presentation with 15 minutes of Q&A, a boardroom round with a protected 3-minute recommendation followed by a 22-minute discussion with judges, a traditional case with 20 minutes plus 10 minutes of Q&A, and a 20+15 final. **Every team member must speak in every round.** Two ground rules shape the language below: never identify your school of origin to a judge (instant disqualification — you present as your drawn team letter, e.g. "Team C"), and Implementation & Resources is the heaviest rubric category (2.5x), so your English must be sharpest where you talk money, timelines, and resources. Everything here is deliberately short: under pressure you will only retrieve phrases of five to ten words.

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1. DE–EN terminology

Finance and accounting

Deutsch	English	Note
der Umsatz	revenue, sales	Prefer "revenue" in North America; "turnover" often means staff fluctuation
die Umsatzrendite	return on sales, net margin	
der Deckungsbeitrag	contribution margin	
die Bruttomarge	gross margin	
das Betriebsergebnis	operating profit, EBIT	
der Jahresüberschuss	net income, net profit	
die Gewinn- und Verlustrechnung	income statement, P&L	
die Bilanz	balance sheet	Never just "balance"
das Eigenkapital	equity	
das Fremdkapital	debt, borrowed capital	
die Verbindlichkeiten	liabilities, payables	
die Forderungen	receivables	
das Umlaufvermögen	current assets	
das Anlagevermögen	fixed assets	
die Abschreibung	depreciation (tangibles), amortization (intangibles)	
die Rückstellung	provision, accrual	
die Provision	commission	**False friend** — see box below
der Kapitalwert	net present value (NPV)	
der Abzinsungssatz	discount rate	
die Amortisationszeit	payback period	Not "amortization period"
die Gewinnschwelle	break-even point	
die Gemeinkosten	overhead(s)	
fixe / variable Kosten	fixed / variable costs	
die Milliarde	billion	**False friend** — see box below

Strategy and corporate

Deutsch	English	Note
der Konzern	group, corporation	**False friend** — see box below
der Mittelstand	mid-sized companies, SMEs	No exact equivalent; explain if used
das Kerngeschäft	core business	
die Kernkompetenz	core competency	
der Wettbewerbsvorteil	competitive advantage	
das Alleinstellungsmerkmal	unique selling proposition (USP)	
die Wertschöpfungskette	value chain	
der Markteintritt	market entry	
der Marktanteil	market share	
die Übernahme	acquisition, takeover	
die Handlungsempfehlung	recommendation	“Recommended course of action” if formal
die Annahme	assumption	
die Machbarkeit	feasibility, viability	
die Maßnahme	initiative, action	“Measure” is correct but stiff

Marketing and sales

Deutsch	English	Note
die Marke	brand	
die Markenbekanntheit	brand awareness	
die Zielgruppe	target group, target segment	
die Kundenbindung	customer retention, loyalty	
die Kundenabwanderung	churn	
die Kundengewinnungskosten	customer acquisition cost (CAC)	
der Kundenlebenszeitwert	customer lifetime value (CLV)	
die Preisgestaltung	pricing	
der Vertriebskanal	sales channel, distribution channel	
der Einzelhandel	retail	
das Sortiment	product range, assortment	
der Mehrwert	added value	

Operations and implementation

Deutsch	English	Note
die Umsetzung	implementation, execution	Your most important word: rubric weight 2.5x
die Lieferkette	supply chain	
die Beschaffung	procurement, sourcing	
der Lagerbestand	inventory	
die Auslastung	(capacity) utilization	
der Engpass	bottleneck, constraint	
die Durchlaufzeit	lead time	
die Skaleneffekte	economies of scale	
das Personal	staff, workforce	“Personnel” is formal; “personal” is an adjective
der Fachkräftemangel	skilled-labour shortage	
der Meilenstein	milestone	
der Zeitplan	timeline, schedule	

Statistics and data

Deutsch	English	Note
die Stichprobe	sample	
die Grundgesamtheit	population	

Deutsch	English	Note
der Mittelwert	mean, average	
die Standardabweichung	standard deviation	
der Ausreißer	outlier	
die Kennzahl	metric, key figure, KPI	
die Prognose	forecast	
die Hochrechnung	extrapolation, projection	
die Wachstumsrate	growth rate	Average annual = CAGR
die Verzerrung	bias	
aussagekräftig	meaningful, robust (of data)	

False friends that will hurt you

German word	It means	The trap
die Milliarde	**billion** (10^9)	German "Billion" = English **trillion** (10^12). Get this wrong and your market size is off by a factor of 1,000
eventuell	possibly, perhaps	"Eventually" means it *will* happen in the end ("schließlich"). "Eventually we partner" is a promise, not an option
der Konzern	group, corporation	English "concern" = Sorge, Anliegen ("a valid concern")
die Provision	commission	English "provision" = Rückstellung — an accounting term. Sales reps earn *commission*
sensibel	sensitive	"Sensible" = vernünftig. Customers are *price-sensitive*; a plan is *sensible*
aktuell	current	"Actually" = tatsächlich. Say "currently", never "actually" for "zurzeit"
konsequent	consistent, rigorous	"Consequently" = folglich
bekommen	to get, to receive	"To become" = werden. You *get* a discount; you do not become one
der Chef	boss, CEO	A "chef" cooks

2. Presentation phrase bank

Openings. State the recommendation within the first minute — judges score "Framing the problem". Never name your school; you are your team letter.

- "Good morning, and thank you for the opportunity to present."
- "We are Team C, and over the next twenty minutes we will show you how [Client] can [headline result]."
- "Our recommendation in one sentence: [X]. Here is why — and how."
- "[Client] faces one core question: [question]. Our answer is yes, and it pays for itself in [n] months."
- "Three things today: the problem, our answer, and exactly how to make it happen."

Signposting. One signpost per section; keep it to a single breath.

- "Let me start with the problem."
- "That brings me to the financials."
- "So much for the market — now the money."
- "The key takeaway from this slide is simple: [X]."
- "Here is where it gets interesting."
- "We looked at three options and kept one."
- "And now the part that matters most: implementation."

Handovers between speakers. All four members must speak, so you will hand over at least three times. One sentence out, half a sentence in — never re-introduce the deck.

- "With that, I will hand over to Anna, who will walk you through the financials."
- "For the numbers behind this, over to Jonas."
- "Lena will now show you how we de-risk the rollout."
- Receiving: "Thank you, Maria. As she said, the margin is the lever — here is how we pull it."
- Receiving: "Thanks, Jonas. Building on that market picture, …"

Closing the ask. End on implementation, cost, and payback — the heaviest rubric line. The yellow card means five minutes left; the red card means one.

- "To sum up: we recommend [X]. It costs [Y], breaks even in [Z], and the first milestone is in April."
- "This is feasible with the team and budget [Client] already has."
- "The ask today: approve [X] and a budget of [Y], and we start in Q2."
- "If you remember one number, make it this one: [n]."
- Under the red card: "I see the red card — let me close with the essentials: [three short points]. Thank you. We are happy to take your questions."

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3. Q&A under fire

Q&A runs 10–15 minutes depending on the round, in front of industry judges. Rule one: **answer first, explain second.** Rule two: short beats complete.

Answer-first stems

- "Yes — and here is why."
- "No, and deliberately so: …"
- "The short answer is [X]. The reasoning: …"
- "Two things. First … second …"
- "It depends on one variable: [X]. If it rises, we …"
- "We tested exactly that. The result was …"

Bridging (when the question is hostile, narrow, or off-track)

- "That touches on our second risk. Our mitigation is …"
- "The underlying question is whether [X] — and our answer is yes, because …"
- "Fair point on the detail; the bigger picture is …"
- "Let me answer that and then connect it back to the recommendation."

Polite disagreement (disagree with the premise, never with the person)

- "That is a fair challenge. We saw it differently, and here is why."
- "I would push back gently on one assumption there."
- "We considered that option and ruled it out, for two reasons."
- "You are right about the risk; we differ on its size."
- Conceding well: "That is a good catch — our estimate is conservative there. The recommendation still holds because …"

Buying two seconds without "ähm"

- "That is a fair question."
- "Good question — let me take the financing part first."
- Repeat the key noun back: "The rollout timeline. Two points."
- Or simply pause, breathe, then answer. Two seconds of silence read as composure; two seconds of "ähm" read as panic.
- Banned fillers (they slip out in English too): "ähm", "genau", "also", "sozusagen", and the tag "…or?" (a direct translation of "oder?" — it does not exist in English).

When you missed the question acoustically

- "I'm sorry, I didn't catch the last part — could you repeat it?"
- "Could you say that again? I want to make sure I answer the right question."
- Paraphrase check: "If I understood correctly, you are asking about [X] — is that right?"
- Teammate rescue (agree on this beforehand): "I believe the question was about [X] — I can take that."
- Never bluff an answer you did not hear. Asking once is professional; guessing wrong is not.

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4. Boardroom register

The boardroom round is different: after your protected three minutes (one summary slide, uninterrupted), you sit through a **22-minute discussion** with the judges — in past editions including a company representative. This is a conversation, not a lecture, and every member must speak during it. The register is collegial and interactive.

Inviting

- "Happy to go deeper on the numbers if that is useful."
- "May I ask how you see the trade-off between [X] and [Y]?"
- "What would need to be true for this to be a yes for you?"
- "Is there a part of the plan you would like us to stress-test?"

Building

- "To build on that point …"
- "Exactly — and that is why we phased the rollout."
- "That connects to what Jonas said earlier about capacity."
- "Yes — and one number supports that: …"

Redirecting

- "That is an important point — may I link it back to the margin question?"
- "Before we leave the financials, one number I would like on the table: …"
- "We are conscious of time, so let me summarize where we have landed."
- "Can I park that for a moment and come back to it? I want to answer the funding question first."

Bringing in a teammate (use this deliberately — it is how everyone gets speaking time)

- "Lena owns this part of the model — Lena?"
- "I will let our finance lead take that."
- "Maria ran that analysis; she can give you the exact figure."

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5. Numbers out loud

Numbers are where German habits are most audible. Six rules:

1. **Decimal point, not comma.** German 3,5 is English 3.5 — "three point five." Thousands separators flip too: 1.500.000 becomes 1,500,000.
2. **Percent never takes a plural.** "Seven percent," not "seven percents." A *change* between two percentages is measured in **percentage points**: "up three points, from 9 to 12 percent."
3. **Currency after the number when speaking.** Written "$1.5m," spoken "one point five million dollars." First mention in Winnipeg: "Canadian dollars"; after that, "dollars."
4. **Magnitudes:** Million = million; **Milliarde = billion; Billion = trillion.** Drill this until it is reflex.
5. **Years and dates:** 2027 is "twenty twenty-seven." February 18 is "February eighteenth." Fiscal year 2026 is "FY twenty-six."
6. **Negatives and ranges:** "minus" or "down": "NPV falls to minus 340,000 dollars"; "between five and seven percent" or "five to seven percent."

Twelve practice sentences. Read aloud daily; record yourself weekly. Spoken forms of the traps are in brackets.

1. Revenue grew by 4.7% ["four point seven percent"] to $23.5 million ["twenty-three point five million dollars"].
2. Gross margin improved from 38.2% to 41.5% — an increase of 3.3 percentage points.
3. The project requires an upfront investment of $1.2 million and breaks even after 14 months.
4. We assume a discount rate of 8% and a terminal growth rate of 1.5%.
5. The Canadian market is worth 2.3 billion Canadian dollars [Milliarden!], growing at a CAGR ["C-A-G-R"] of 6.1%.
6. Unit costs fall from $4.60 ["four dollars sixty" or "four sixty"] to $3.95, a saving of roughly 14%.
7. In the worst case, NPV drops to minus $340,000 ["three hundred and forty thousand dollars"].
8. Phase one runs from March to June 2027 ["twenty twenty-seven"]; phase two starts on July 1st ["July first"].
9. Two-thirds of customers are under 35, and one in four buys online.
10. Headcount rises from 48 to 63 FTEs — that is, by about 31%.
11. The debt-to-equity ratio is 1.8 to 1 ["one point eight to one"].
12. Sales tripled between 2024 and 2026 — from $0.9 million ["zero point nine" or "nine hundred thousand

dollars”] to $2.7 million.

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6. Pronunciation traps for German speakers

th. Two sounds — never s, z, t, or d. Tongue touches the teeth. Voiceless */θ/*: *think, three, third, thousand, threshold, growth, monthly, strengths, worth.* Voiced /ð/: *this, that, therefore, rather, either, whether.* Drill line: “We think this third growth path is worth three thousand.”

v vs. w. Germans swap in both directions. **v** = upper teeth on lower lip: *value, invest, revenue, viable, leverage, review, innovation.* **w** = rounded lips, no teeth: *we, would, win, workforce, worldwide, quarter* (kw-). Minimal pairs: *vest/west, vine/wine, verse/worse.* Drill line: “We will invest in value this winter.”

-ed endings. Three variants — and beware German final devoicing (Auslautverhärtung), which turns “planned” into “plant”:

- /t/ after voiceless sounds: *launched, increased, priced, reduced, fixed*
- /d/ after voiced sounds — keep the d voiced: *planned, positioned, delivered, phased, designed*
- /ɪd/ as an extra syllable only after t or d: *implemented, expected, invested, decided, targeted*

Never add /ɪd/ elsewhere: “launched” has one syllable, not two.

Word stress. English moves stress within word families; German speakers tend to keep it fixed.

- **STRAT**-egy, but stra-**TE**-gic
- **AN**-a-lyze, a-**NAL**-y-sis, plural a-**NAL**-y-ses (ends in “-seez” /si:z/ — different from the singular)
- e-**CON**-o-my, ec-o-**NOM**-ics, ec-o-**NOM**-i-cal
- **COM**-pe-tent, com-**PET**-i-tor, com-pe-**TI**-tion
- de-**VEL**-op-ment (never “develop-MENT”), per-**CENT**, ho-**TEL**, e-**VENT**
- Noun vs. verb: an **IN**-crease / to in-**CREASE**; a **RE**-cord / to re-**CORD**; a **PRO**-ject (noun — the verb is rare)

Silent letters and finance-specific words. *debt* = “det” (silent b), *receipt* = “re-SEET” (silent p), *doubt, subtle* (silent b), *margin* with a soft g (“MAR-jin”), *niche* (“neesh” or “nitch” — pick one and stay consistent), *suite* = “sweet” (a hotel suite; a *suit* is what you wear), *hierarchy* = “HIGH-er-ar-kee”, *says* = “sez”.

Daily two-minute drill. Run this word ladder before every mock presentation: *three — this — growth — strengths — value — we — viable — workforce — launched — planned — implemented — strategy — strategic — analysis — analyses — competitor — development — percent — debt — margin.* Then one full sentence: “Our strategic analysis shows a viable path to three percent growth, with the debt repaid by twenty twenty-nine.”

Practice routine: one section per training week, and English as the working language of every mock session. By Winnipeg these phrases should be muscle memory, not vocabulary.